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February 2024 | Poll Finding

KFF Health Tracking Poll: Economic Views and Experiences of Adults Who Struggle Financially

Alex Montero, Audrey Kearney, Isabelle Valdes, Ashley Kirzinger, Liz Hamel

About half of adults say they either have difficulty affording monthly bills or are *just* able to afford their household expenses without having money left over, according to the latest KFF Tracking Poll. These groups are much more likely than those who can afford their monthly costs with money left over to rate the national economy negatively and worry about affording everyday expenses. Worries about health care costs, however, pervade regardless of financial situation, with a majority of adults who can afford their bills with money left over saying they worry about affording unexpected medical bills or the cost of health care services. Thinking ahead to the upcoming 2024 presidential election, voters who have difficulty affording household expenses are more likely than others to say it is "very important" for presidential candidates to discuss inflation and affordability of health care on the campaign trail.

Assessments of the national economy are historically linked to presidential approval, and KFF's latest tracking poll reflects this, with large shares of Republicans describing the economy negatively compared to fewer than half of Democrats saying the same. Yet at least three quarters of adults who report difficulty affording bills or say they can *just* afford their bills rate the economy negatively, suggesting that negative perceptions of the economy, at least in part, also reflect adults' personal financial situations.

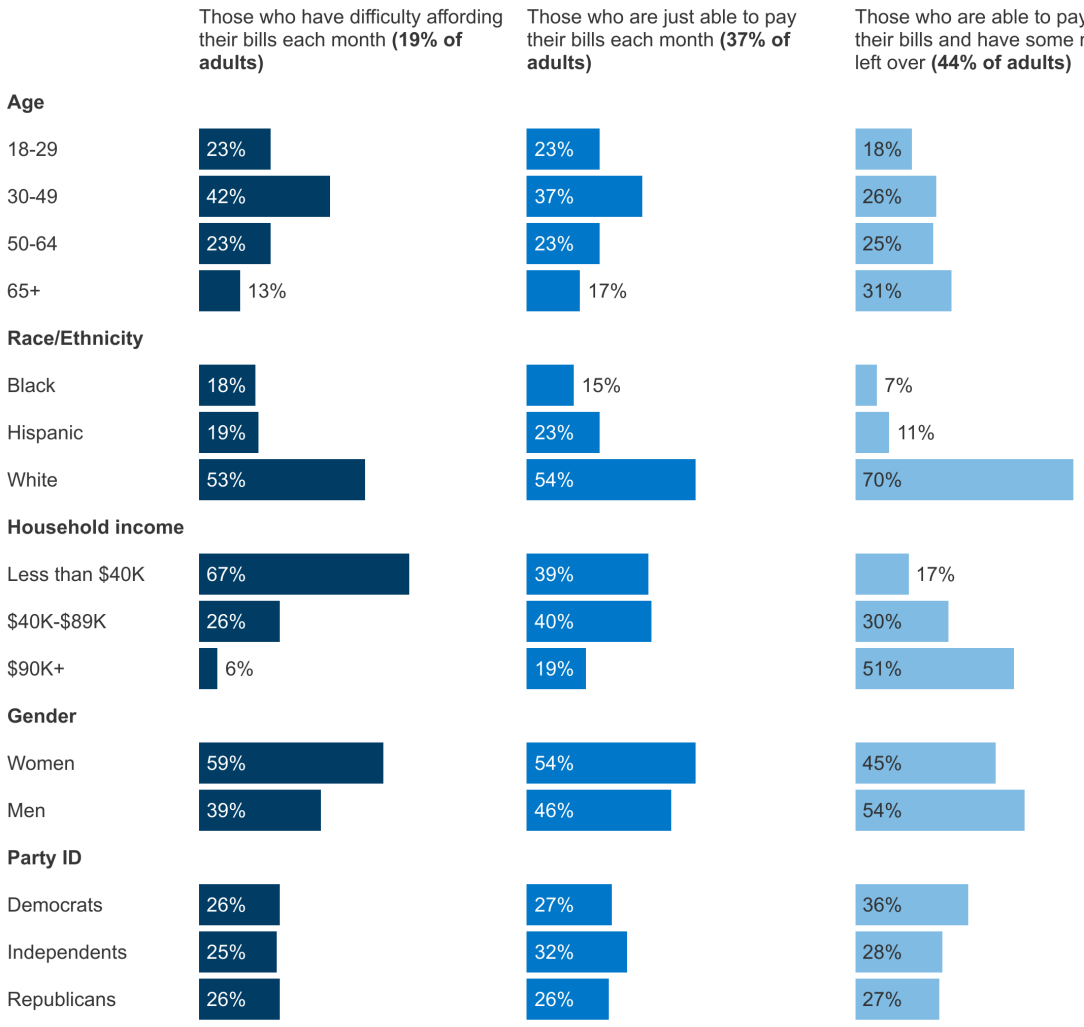
Who Struggles Affording Monthly Bills?

About one in five adults (19%) say they have difficulty affording their bills each month and about four in ten (37%) say they are *just* able to afford their bills each month, while a little over four in ten (44%) say they are both able to pay their bills and have some money left over.

Adults who have difficulty affording their monthly bills as well as those who are just able to pay their bills each month are younger and have lower household incomes compared to adults who say they can afford their bills each month with money left over. These groups are also disproportionately made up of Black adults, Hispanic adults, and women. The groups struggling to afford household expenses are equally made up of Democrats, independents, and Republicans, while adults who say they can afford their monthly bills with money left over are more likely to be Democrats than independents or Republicans.

Figure 1

Demographics Of Adults By Self-Reported Financial Situation



NOTE: See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Jan. 30-Feb. 7, 2024)

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Majorities of adults who report difficulty affording their monthly bills and those who are *just* able to afford their bills say they are worried about affording expenses for themselves and their family, from health care costs to food and paying down debt. About nine in ten adults who have difficulty affording their monthly bills are “very” or “somewhat worried” about being able to afford their monthly utilities like electricity and heat (95%), food (90%), or their rent or mortgage (88%) for themselves or their family. Similarly large majorities of the group who can *just* afford their bills also say they are worried about affording monthly utilities (80%), food (77%), or their rent or mortgage (76%).

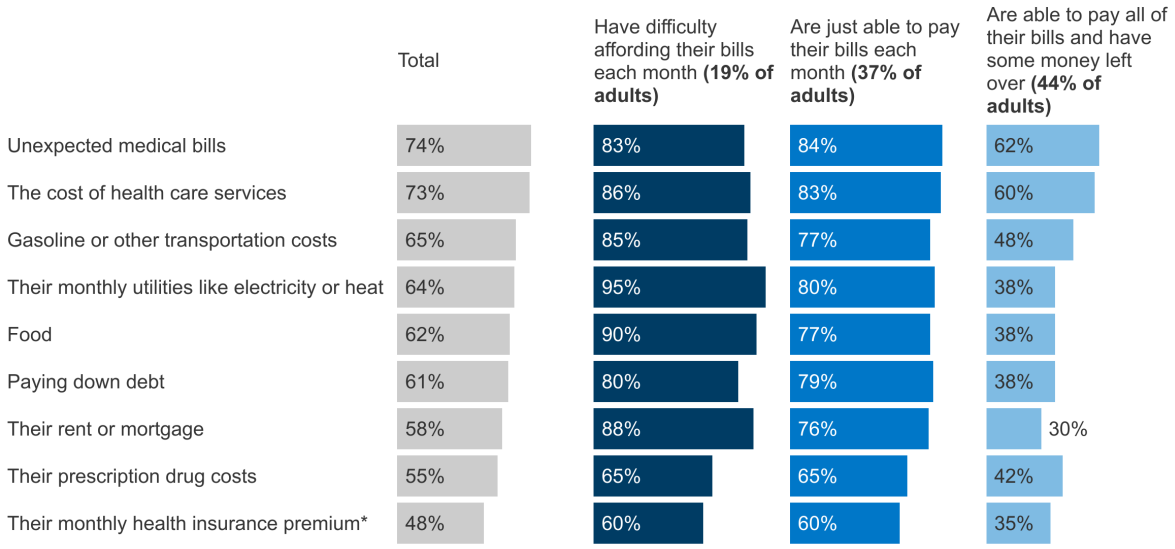
Health care costs are also a concern for those who struggle with bills, with more than eight in ten saying they are worried about the cost of health care services (86%) or unexpected medical bills (83%). Among those who are *just* able to afford their bills, about eight in ten are worried about being able to afford unexpected medical bills (84%) or health care services (83%). Fewer, but still majority shares, of both these groups report being worried about affording prescription drug costs (65% for each), and – among those with health insurance – their monthly health insurance premium (60%).

Notably, worry about health care costs pervade among a majority of adults, regardless of their financial situation. Six in ten adults who say they can afford their bills with money left over nonetheless say they are "very" or "somewhat worried" about being able to afford unexpected medical bills (62%) or the cost of health care services (60%) for themselves and their family. For this group, larger shares worry about affording health care services and unexpected medical bills than other expenses like housing, food, and utilities, perhaps reflecting anxieties associated with the uncertainty and potential high costs of a prospective medical episode.

Figure 2

Majorities Of Adults Who Struggle To Afford Monthly Bills And Those Who Can Just Pay Their Bills Report Worrying About Most Everyday Costs

Percent of adults who say they are **very** or **somewhat worried** about being able to afford the following for themselves or their family:



NOTE: *Item asked of adults with health insurance. See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Jan. 30-Feb. 7, 2024)

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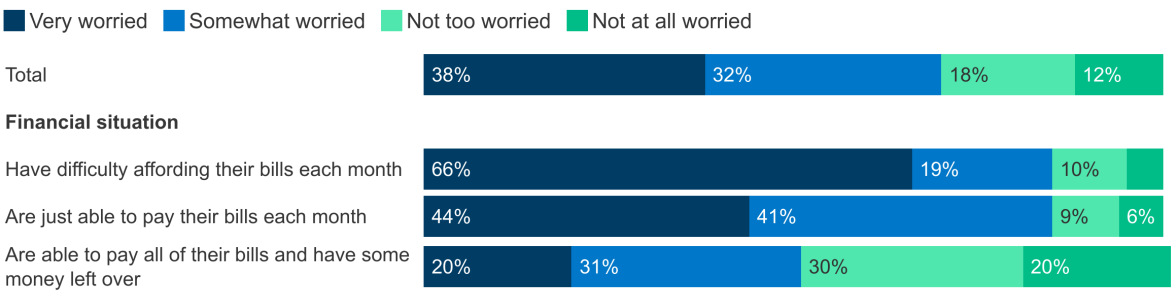
Beyond affordability worries, large shares of adults overall – including even larger shares of those who have difficulty affording bills or can *just* afford their bills – express worry about the prospect of medical

debt, which prior KFF polling has found is held by about four in ten U.S. adults. Overall, seven in ten (70%) adults say they are “very” or “somewhat worried” a medical or dental bill will put them into debt or add to their current debt. Over eight in ten (85%) adults who struggle to afford their monthly bills say they are worried a medical or dental bill will put them in debt or add to their debt, including two-thirds (66%) of this group who say they are “very worried” about the prospect of taking on medical debt. Similar shares of the group that can just afford their bills also worry about health care debt, with 85% saying they are “very” or “somewhat worried” a medical or dental bill will lead to debt or add to their debt. Half (51%) of adults who can afford their bills with money left over report worrying that a bill will put them into health care debt or add to their debt.

Figure 3

Over Eight In Ten Adults Who Struggle To Pay Bills And Those Who Can Just Pay Their Bills Report Worrying About Going Into Medical Debt

How worried are you that a medical or dental bill will put you in debt or add to your current debt?



NOTE: See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Jan. 30-Feb. 7, 2024)

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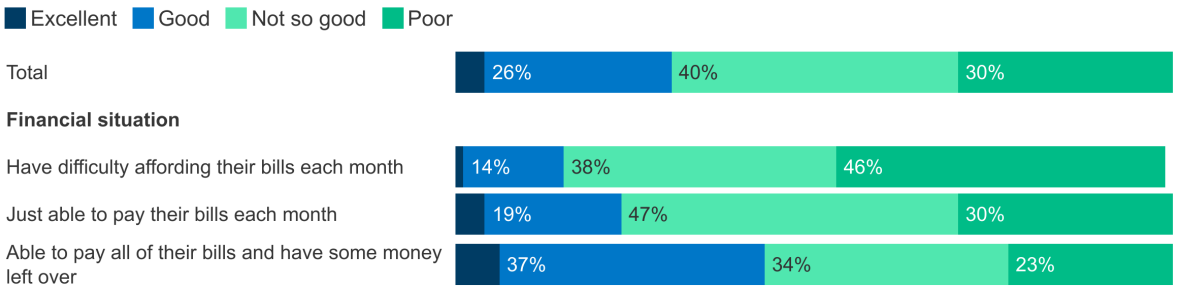
How Personal Finances Impact Views of National Economy and Politics

Adults who struggle with their monthly bills are much more likely than those who are able to afford bills to rate the economy negatively, even as recent news reports have emphasized an improving national economy, although inflation rates have recently remained higher than expected. While there are notable partisan divides on the economy, with Republican voters much more likely than Democratic voters to rate the economy negatively, views on the economy also differ by financial situation. More than eight in ten adults (84%) who report difficulty affording their bills say the national economy is either “not so good” or “poor,” as do three-fourths (77%) of those who are just able to afford their monthly bills. These assessments of the national economy are at least twenty percentage points more negative than the views of adults who can afford their bills with money left over (57%).

Figure 4

Adults Who Report Difficulty Affording Monthly Bills Are More Likely Than Those Who Are Able To Afford Bills To Rate The Economy Negatively

Would you describe the condition of the national economy these days as excellent, good, not so good, or poor?



NOTE: See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Jan. 30-Feb. 7, 2024)

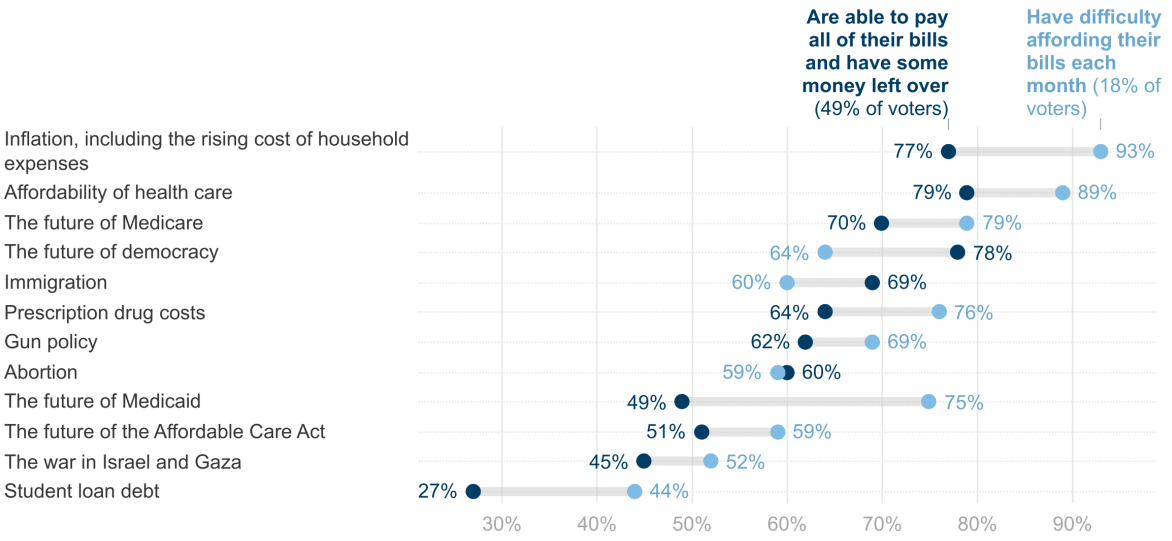
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Voters struggling to afford their monthly costs are more likely to say they want to hear the 2024 presidential candidates discuss economic issues and the future of Medicaid, suggesting that these issues may resonate even more with these voters during the presidential campaign. However, a majority of voters, regardless of financial situation, say they want to hear about cost issues. Voters who have trouble affording their monthly bills are more likely than those who can afford their bills with money left over to say it is “very important” for the 2024 presidential candidates to talk about several economic and health care related issues such as inflation (93% v. 77%), affordability of health care (89% v. 79%), prescription drug costs (76% v. 64%), the future of Medicaid (75% v. 49%) and student loan debt (44% v. 27%).

Figure 5

Voters Who Have Difficulty Affording Monthly Bills Are More Likely To Say It Is Important For 2024 Candidates To Talk About Economic, Health Care Issues

Percent of voters who say it is **very important** for 2024 presidential candidates to talk about each of the following:



NOTE: Among registered voters. See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Jan. 30-Feb. 7, 2024)

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Large Shares of Voters Who Are Struggling to Afford Monthly Bills Say Trump Has Done More to Address Health Care Costs

Former President Trump may be reaping the benefits of retrospective views when voters are asked which president did more in office to address health care costs, while criticism of President Biden may be largely a result of general dissatisfaction with the current state of the economy. The groups of voters who struggle to afford their bills or can *just* afford their bills are more likely to say former President Trump did more than President Biden to address health care costs.

Six in ten (59%) voters who report difficulty affording their bills and about half (52%) of those who can just afford their bills say former President Trump did more as president to address health care costs than President Biden, while more than half of voters (56%) who can afford their bills with money left over side with Biden.

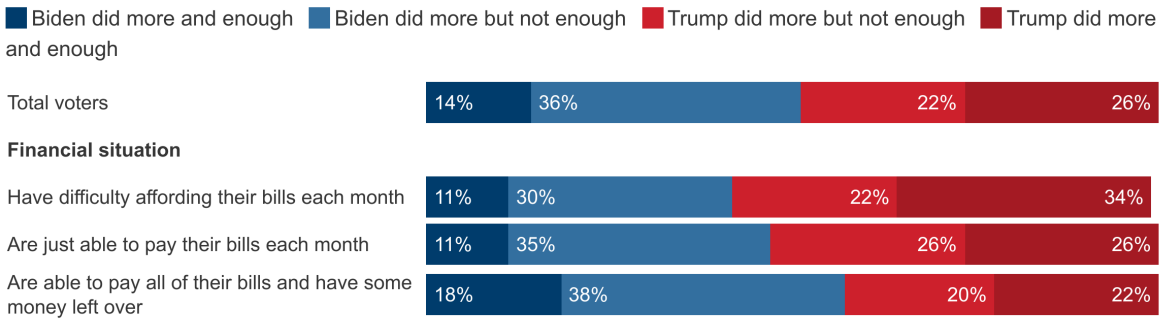
On the question of whether each president did *enough* to address health care costs, one-third (34%) of voters who have difficulty affording their monthly bills say former President Trump did *enough* to address

health care costs, compared to one in ten (11%) who say President Biden has done enough to address the cost of health care. The group of voters who have difficulty affording bills are also more likely than those who can afford their bills with money left over to say former President Trump did enough to address health care costs (34% v. 22%).

Figure 6

Voters Who Struggle Financially Are More Likely Than Others To Say Former President Trump Did More To Address Health Care Costs Than President Biden

Who do you think did more as president to address health care costs? Do you think they did **enough**?



NOTE: Among registered voters. See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Jan. 30-Feb. 7, 2024)

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December 2023 | Poll Finding

KFF Health Tracking Poll: Health Care Issues Emerge as Important Topics on 2024 Campaign Trail, Plus Concerns Loom Large Around Medicaid Unwinding

Audrey Kearney, Isabelle Valdes, Ashley Kirzinger, Grace Sparks, Mollyann Brodie

Key Takeaways

- With the 2024 presidential election cycle in full swing, voters want to hear the candidates talk about many different issues, and voters identify inflation, including the rising cost of household expenses, as the most important topic for discussion. Notably, the affordability of health care came in a close second with eight in ten voters saying it is "very important" for candidates to discuss on the campaign trail.
- Once a longstanding issue for the Republican Party, former President Trump has recently resurrected the debate around the future of the 2010 Affordable Care Act (ACA). Surveyed prior to this discussion, Democratic voters are more than twice as likely as Republicans voters to say the future of the ACA is a "very important" issue for the candidates to discuss (70% v. 32%). The Democratic Party holds an advantage on which party voters trust to do a better job of handling the ACA with six in ten (59%) voters saying they trust the Democratic Party more, compared to four in ten (39%) who say they trust the Republican Party more. Partisans differ, with nearly all Democratic voters saying they trust the Democratic Party (94%), while three in four (77%) Republican voters say they trust the Republican Party. The Democratic Party holds the advantage among independent voters (61% v. 36%).
- The 2024 election will be the first presidential election since the *Dobbs* decision. While few voters overall (4%) say abortion is the "most important" issue for 2024 presidential candidates to talk about as they campaign, the Democratic Party holds a strong advantage over the Republican Party on voters' trust to handle abortion (58% vs. 41%). The Democratic Party hold the advantage on trust on this issue across key voting blocs including women voters overall (61%), women voters ages 18 to 49 (66%), independent women voters (66%), and almost all Democratic women voters (94%).
- While two-thirds of the public now say abortion should be legal in "all" or "most" cases, most voters (57%) say a candidate's position on abortion is only one of many factors in their vote choice. About a quarter of voters (24%) say they would only vote for a candidate who shares their views on the issue, including larger shares of Democratic voters (33%), including three in ten Democratic women (31%) and one-third of Democratic men (35%) – groups where large majorities say abortions should be legal. Notably, one in four (27%) Republican voters who believe abortion should be **illegal** in "all" or "most" cases also say they would only vote for a candidate who shares their views on abortion. Among

Republican voters who believe abortion should be **legal** in all or most cases, very few (4%) say they would only vote for a candidate who shares their views on the issue.

- The poll also takes a look at public awareness around two key health policy issues including the unwinding of the Medicaid continuous enrollment provision and the prescription drug provisions included in the 2022 Inflation Reduction Act, revealing that most of the public is unaware of these actions. Medicaid enrollees themselves are among the most likely to say they are aware of the unwinding, but still a majority say they have heard either "nothing" or "only a little" about the unwinding. Among those who are aware, large majorities are worried that this means many adults and children will become uninsured.

Key Issues in the 2024 Election

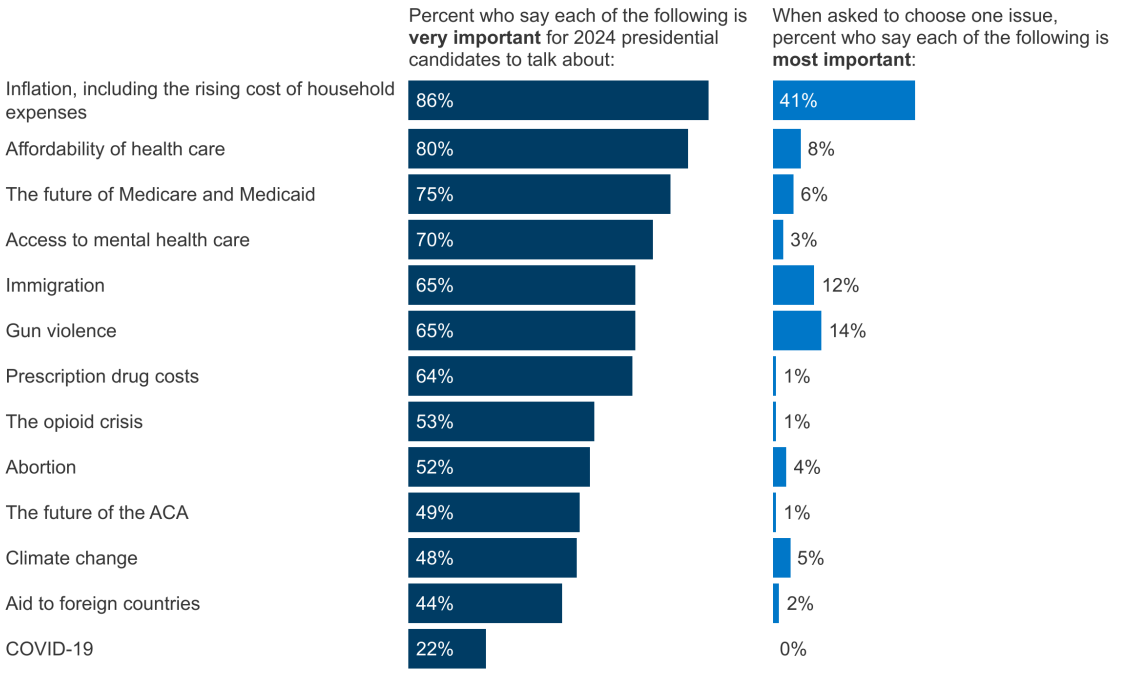
Less than one year until the 2024 election, there are many issues that voters are eager to hear about from presidential candidates, with two economic issues topping the list: inflation and the affordability of health care. Although inflation is now at a 2-year low, consumers continue to notice high prices. At least eight in ten voters say it is "very important" for the 2024 presidential candidates to talk about inflation (86%) or affordability of health care (80%). These are closely followed by the future of Medicare and Medicaid (75%) and access to mental health care (70%). About two-thirds of voters say it is "very important" for candidates to discuss immigration (65%), gun violence (65%) and prescription drug costs (64%) while on the campaign trail. For about half of voters, it is "very important" that candidates discuss the opioid crisis (53%), abortion (52%), the future of the ACA (49%), and climate change (48%), while fewer say it is "very important" for candidates to discuss aid to foreign countries (44%). On the other hand, fewer than one-fourth (22%) of voters say it is "very important" for candidates to be discussing COVID-19 heading into the 2024 election.

When asked to pick their top issue, four in ten (41%) voters say the "most important" issue for candidates to discuss is inflation, including the rising cost of household expenses. This is about three times the share of voters who say any other issue is the "most important" for candidates to discuss, such as gun violence (14%) or immigration (12%). Fewer voters say the affordability of health care (8%), the future of Medicare and Medicaid (6%), climate change (5%), abortion (4%), access to mental health care (3%), aid to foreign countries (2%), the opioid crisis (1%), prescription drug costs (1%), or the future of the Affordable Care Act are the "most important" topics on the campaign trail.

Figure 1

Inflation, Affordability Of Health Care Are Among The Most Important For Candidates To Discuss

Among voters:



NOTE: Among registered voters. See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Oct. 31-Nov. 7, 2023)

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Partisan voters differ slightly on what issues they want the presidential candidates to discuss on the campaign trail. For Democratic voters, nine in ten say it is “very important” that candidates talk about affordability of health care (90%) and gun violence (89%), followed by about eight in ten who say inflation (81%) and access to mental health care (78%) are “very important.” The list of issues that are important to Republicans differs slightly, with nearly all Republican voters (96%) saying it is “very important” that inflation is discussed, eight in ten (82%) saying immigration is “very important,” and about seven in ten wanting to hear about the affordability of health care (71%) or the future of Medicare and Medicaid (70%).

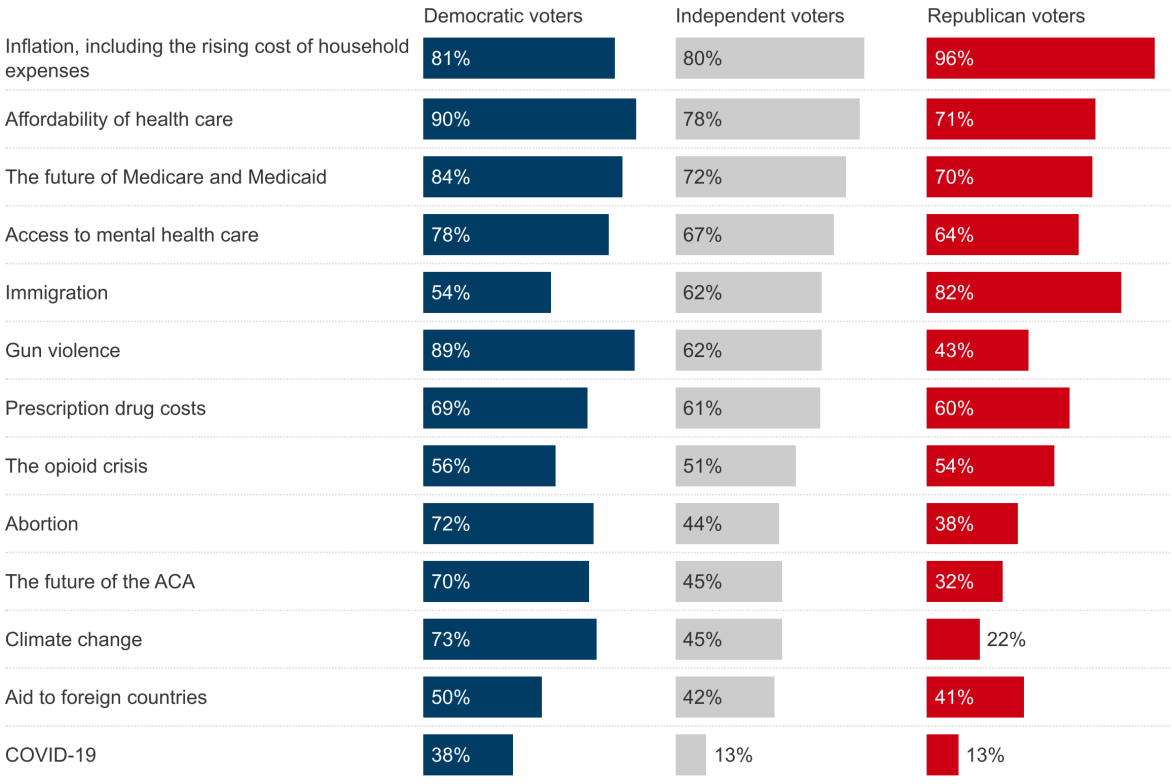
Further down the list for partisans, some of the most polarized issues are climate change, with Democratic voters 51 percentage points more likely than Republicans to say this is a “very important” issue for candidates to talk about (73% v. 22%). Nearly three-fourths (72%) of Democratic voters say that abortion is a “very important” issue for candidates to discuss, compared to about four in ten (38%) Republican voters who say the same (a 34 percentage point difference). The future of the Affordable Care Act, an issue that was once a key health care issue for Republican voters, is now ranked as a “very important” issue for larger shares of Democratic voters (70%) than Republican voters (32%). This survey

was fielded before former President Donald Trump reignited the issue by announcing that he plans to replace the 2010 health care law.

Figure 2

Large Majorities Across Partisans Say Inflation Is A Very Important Issue To Discuss; Republicans Prioritize Immigration, Democrats Prioritize Gun Violence

Percent of voters who say each of the following issues is **very important** for 2024 presidential candidates to talk about:



NOTE: Among registered voters. See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Oct. 31-Nov. 7, 2023)

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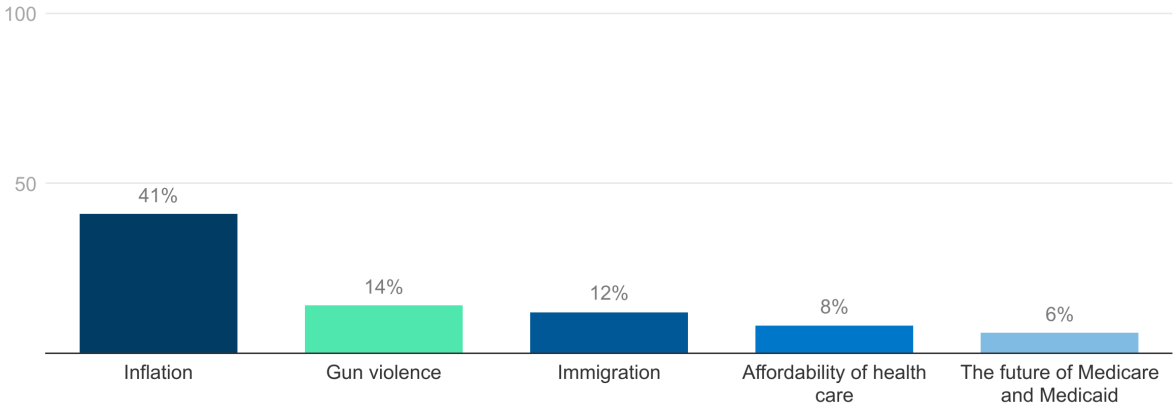
Yet, across partisans and among other key voting groups, inflation emerges among the top issues when voters are asked for their “most important” issue for candidates to discuss. For Democratic voters, Black voters, and voters ages 65 and older, similar shares rank gun violence and inflation as the most important issue. The future of Medicare and Medicaid emerges in the top five issues for adults over age 50, including 13% of adults ages 65 and older, and abortion makes its way into the top five issues for Democratic voters and younger voters.

In the figure below, use the drop-down menu to explore the top five “most important” issues among key subgroups:

Figure 3

Across Groups Of Voters, Inflation Is the Most Important Issue, Tied With Gun Violence For Democratic Voters, Older Voters, And Black Voters

Top five **most important** issues that voters want to hear from 2024 presidential candidates about, among groups of voters:



NOTE: Among registered voters. Items are ranked by the top five most important issues each demographic group of voters want candidates to talk about. In cases where more than five items are shown, items are tied within the group's top five ranking. See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Oct. 31-Nov. 7, 2023)

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When voters are asked which political party they trust to handle each of the issues presented, the Republican Party has a slight edge on inflation and the Democratic Party has the edge on health care related issues, climate change, abortion, and gun violence. Just over half (54%) of voters say they trust the Republican Party to do a better job to address inflation including the rising cost of household expenses, compared to 45% of voters who say they trust the Democratic Party more on this issue. The Republican Party also holds the advantage among voters on immigration (57% v. 41%) and aid to foreign countries (55% v. 41%).

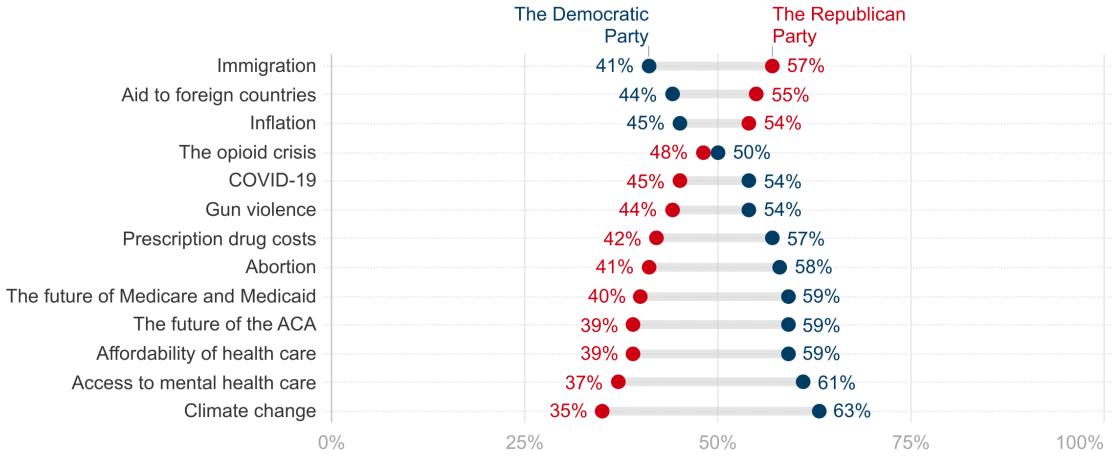
The Democratic Party, however, has the edge on handing health care related issues such as access to mental health care (61% v. 37%), affordability of health care (59% v. 39%), the future of the ACA (59% v. 39%), the future of Medicare and Medicaid (59% v. 40%), abortion (58% v. 41%), and prescription drug costs (57% v. 42%). Nearly two-thirds of voters also say they trust the Democratic Party (63%) over the Republican Party (35%) to address climate change, and more than half (54%) say they trust the Democratic Party over the Republican Party (44%) to do a better job addressing gun violence.

Voters are split on which party they trust to do a better job handling the opioid crisis with half saying they trust the Democratic Party (50%) and a similar share saying they trust the Republican Party (48%).

Figure 4

Democratic Party More Trusted On Key Health Care Issues, Gun Violence, And Climate Change; Republican Party Holds Advantage On Immigration, Foreign Aid, And Inflation

Among voters: Regardless of who you intend to vote for in the upcoming elections, which political party, the Democrats or the Republicans, do you trust to do a better job addressing each of the following?



NOTE: Among registered voters. See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Oct. 31-Nov. 7, 2023)

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Top Issues and Party Trust for Key Voting Groups:

While inflation is the "most important" issue across voters when asked to choose one issue they want to hear from candidates about, other issues emerge for different types of voters. Below is a selection of some key voting groups and issues that are important to them:

The issues that top the list for **Black voters** when asked to select the "most important" issue they want to hear presidential candidates discuss are inflation (32%) and gun violence (31%). On each of these issues, Black voters are at least three times as likely to trust the Democratic Party as the Republican Party.

Voters ages 65 and older want to hear candidates talk about a myriad of issues, including 13% who say that the future of Medicare and Medicaid is the most important issue for candidates to discuss. Six in ten trust the Democratic Party (61%) to handle this, while about four in ten trust the Republican Party (38%).

Half of **rural voters** say inflation is the most important issue for presidential candidates discuss, and six in ten say that they trust the Republican Party better to handle it, compared to four in ten who trust the Democratic Party.

Voters ages 18 to 29 say that the most important issues they want to hear about from candidates are inflation (54%) and the affordability of health care (13%). On inflation and rising household expenses generally, young voters are split, with half saying they trust the Democratic Party and half saying they trust the Republican Party. But, when it comes to health care expenses, two-thirds (68%) say they trust the Democratic Party, while three in ten (31%) say they trust the Republican Party.

Immigration is among the most important issues **White voters** want to hear about from presidential candidates (13% say this is the most important issue), and two-thirds (63%) say they trust the Republican Party better to handle this issue, while one-third (35%) say they trust the Democratic Party.

By far, the most important issue **Hispanic voters** want to hear from candidates about is inflation and the rising cost of household expenses. On this issue, a majority of Hispanic voters say they trust the Democratic Party (57%) while four in ten (43%) say they trust the Republican Party.

For **suburban women**, the most important issue they want to hear about is inflation. On this issue, suburban women are split, with half (52%) saying they trust the Republican party more to handle it, and half (47%) saying they trust the Democratic Party.

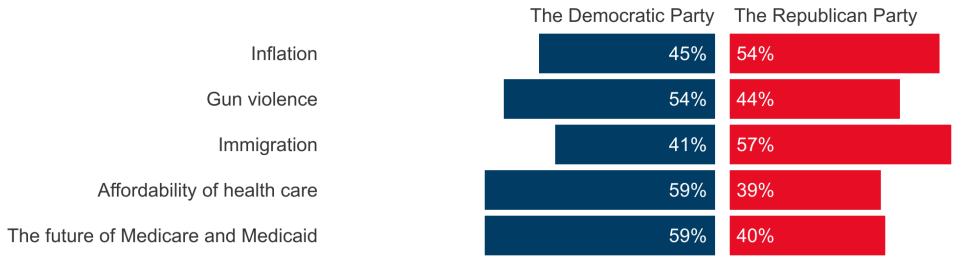
To explore how key groups rank their top five “most important” issues they want candidates to discuss, and which political party they trust on each of those issues, use the toggles on the figure below:

Figure 5

Key Voter Groups And Which Party They Trust To Handle Their Top Five "Most Important" Issues They Want To Hear Candidates Discuss

Total voters | Democratic voters | Independent voters | Republican voters | Black voters | Hispanic voters | White voters | Voters ages 18-29 | Voters ages 65 and older | Women voters | Democratic women | Independent women | Republican women

Regardless of who you intend to vote for in the upcoming elections, which political party do you trust to do a better job addressing each of the following? *Items are ranked by percent who say each is the single "most important" issue they would like to hear candidates discuss.*



NOTE: Top five "most important" issues shown for each demographic group. In cases where there are more than five items are shown, items are tied within the group's top five ranking. See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Oct. 31-Nov. 7, 2023)

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Abortion in the 2024 Election

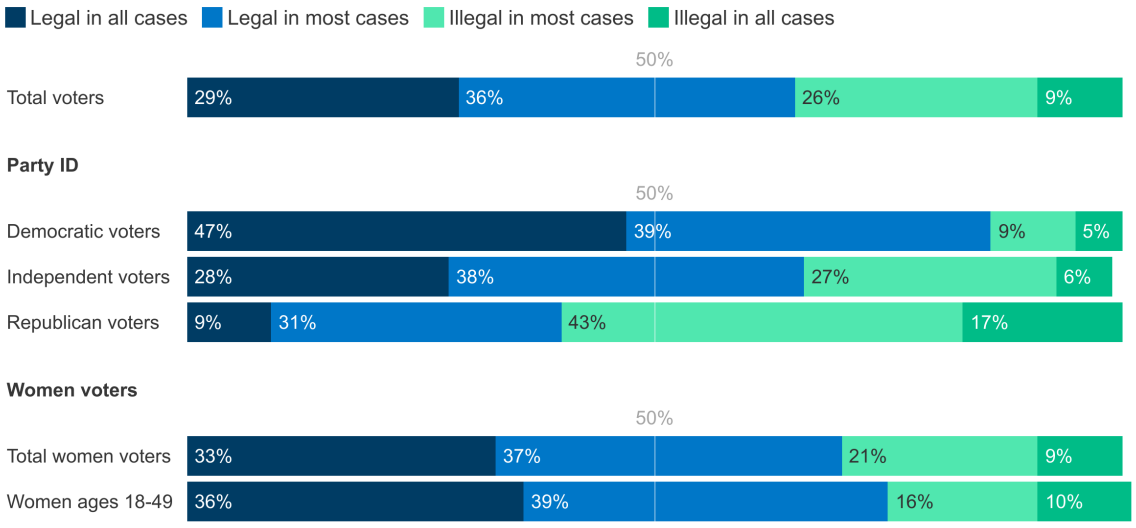
After the *Dobbs* decision overturned *Roe v. Wade* in June 2022, decisions about abortion access are now left up to the states. In October 2023, a few state elections that included abortion-related ballot measures gave some insight into how voters react when presented directly with ballot questions related to abortion rights.

Overall, most voters say they think abortion should be legal in either “all cases” (29%) or “most cases” (36%), while one in four voters say it should be illegal in most (26%) cases and just one in ten (9%) say it should be illegal in all cases. A majority of Democratic voters, independent voters, women, men, and voters across age, racial, and ethnic groups say that abortion should be legal in all or most cases. A majority of Republican voters (60%)—including 55% of Republican women—say that abortion should be illegal in all or most cases. Currently, abortion is banned in 14 states in the U.S., and limited in an additional 11 states.

Figure 6

Most Voters Overall Say Abortion Should Be Legal In All Or Most Cases, Including Four In Ten Republican Voters

Do you think abortion should be:



NOTE: Among registered voters. See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Oct. 31-Nov. 7, 2023)

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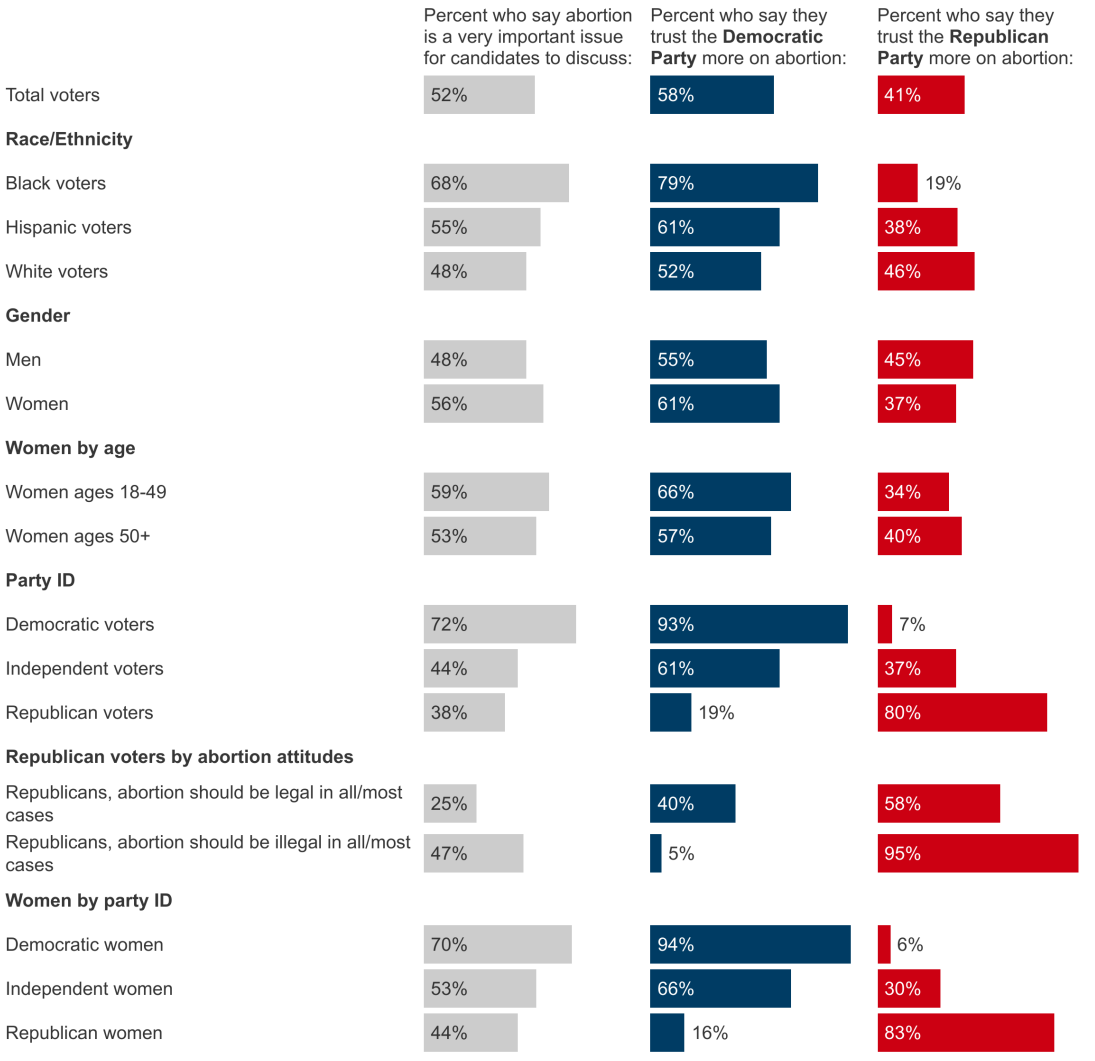
Overall, while most voters say that abortion is an important issue they would like 2024 presidential candidates to discuss, few (4%) voters say it is rises to the *most important* issue to discuss during this campaign. Most Democratic voters (72%), including seven in ten Democratic women, say that abortion is a very important issue for candidates to discuss, as do seven in ten (68%) Black voters and more than half (55%) of Hispanic voters. Yet, it rises to the most important issue for discussion for just one in ten (11%) of Democratic voters, and fewer than five percent of Black or Hispanic voters.

When it comes to which party voters trust to do a better job handling the issue of abortion, majorities across race, ethnicity, and gender say they trust the Democratic Party, as do majorities of Democrats and independents. Republican voters are much more likely to say they trust the Republican Party to handle the issue of abortion (80%), though four in ten (40%) Republican voters who say abortion should be legal in all or most cases say they trust the Democratic Party more on this issue. For these voters, just one-fourth say abortion is a very important issue to them.

Figure 7

Majorities Of Voters Across Race, Ethnicity, And Gender Say They Trust The Democratic Party To Handle The Issue Of Abortion, Though Most Republicans Trust The Republican Party

Among voters:



NOTE: Among registered voters. See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Oct. 31-Nov. 7, 2023)

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While few voters identify abortion as the most important issue for candidates to discuss, it does appear that the issue could influence a small group of voters' decisions during the 2024 election. While most voters (57%) say a candidate's position on abortion is just one of many important factors, one in four (24%) voters say they would *only* vote for a candidate who shares their views on abortion. Larger shares of Democratic voters (33%) say they would only vote for a candidate who shares their view on abortion,

including three in ten (31%) Democratic women. Overall, about one in five voters (19%) say abortion is not an important factor in their vote choice including about three in ten (29%) Republican women.

Abortion does not seem to be a deciding issue in determining which candidates to support for many Republicans, especially those Republicans who think abortion should be **legal** in all or most cases. Just 4% of this group say they would only vote for a candidate who shares their views on abortion, while half (53%) of Republicans who say abortion should be legal say "a candidate's position on abortion is just one of many important factors" and four in ten say abortion is not an important factor in their vote choice. This is compared to the nearly three in ten Republican voters who think that abortion should be **illegal** in all or most cases who say that they would only vote for a candidate who shares their views on abortion.

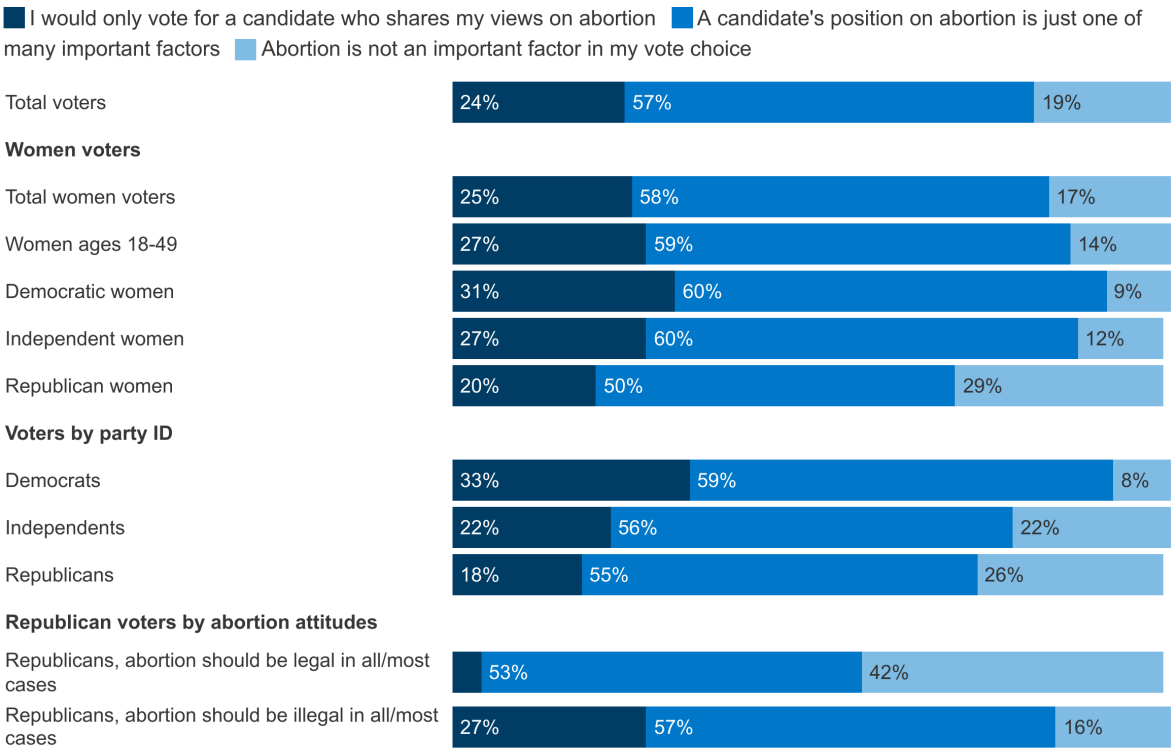
Abortion as a top issue in the election: A Trend Update

Earlier this year, KFF polling began tracking the role abortion may play in the upcoming 2024 election and found that many voters, including large shares of Democratic women voters, were motivated by the *Dobbs* decision to vote. At the time, about half (52%) of Democratic women voters said they would only vote for a candidate who shares their views on abortion, and an additional four in ten (41%) said a candidate's views on abortion is just one of many factors to their vote. Although large shares of Democratic women continue to say that abortion is at least an important factor to their vote, fewer (31%) now say that they would only vote for a candidate who shares their view on abortion. With other issues dominating recent headlines, abortion may be an issue that voters are considering, but not hanging their hat on.

Figure 8

Abortion Is More Of A Deciding Issue For Democratic Voters Than For Republican Voters

Thinking about how the issue of abortion might affect your vote next year, which comes closer to your view:



NOTE: Among registered voters. See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Oct. 31-Nov. 7, 2023)

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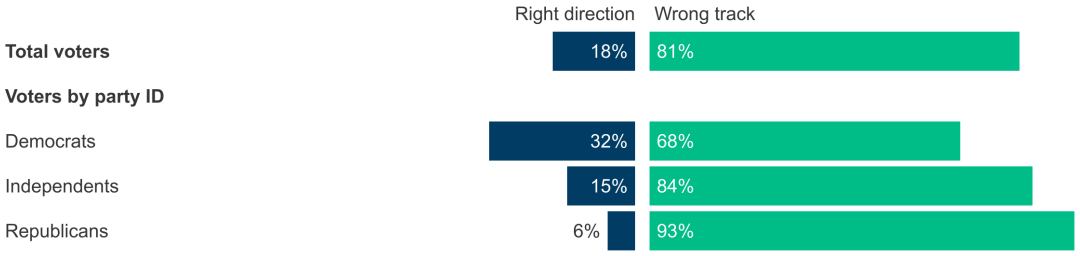
Many Voters are Pessimistic Heading into the 2024 Election

Less than one year until the 2024 election, many voters are not feeling confident with the way things are going in the U.S. Eight in ten (81%) voters say that things in this country “have gotten off on the wrong track,” compared to about one in five (18%) who say things are generally going in the right direction. While this finding is consistent with past polling of voters since 2014, the latest KFF poll shows that Democratic voters are less pessimistic than Republican voters, with about one-third of Democratic voters saying things in the U.S. are generally going in the right direction (32%) and just six percent of Republican voters saying the same.

Figure 9

Voters Are Generally Pessimistic About The Direction The U.S. Is Going, Though Democrats Are Less Pessimistic

Do you feel things in this country are generally going in the right direction or do you feel things have gotten off on the wrong track?



NOTE: Among registered voters. See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Oct. 31-Nov. 7, 2023)

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Voters who say that things in the U.S. have gotten off on the wrong track are most interested in hearing about inflation, including the rising cost of household expenses (46%), from 2024 presidential hopefuls. About six in ten (62%) of these pessimistic voters say they trust the Republican party better to address inflation and the rising cost of household expenses, while about four in ten (37%) say they trust the Democratic Party on this issue. Voters who say things in the U.S. are headed in the right direction are most interested in hearing about gun violence (24%) and inflation (21%), and larger shares say they trust the Democratic Party on each of these issues.

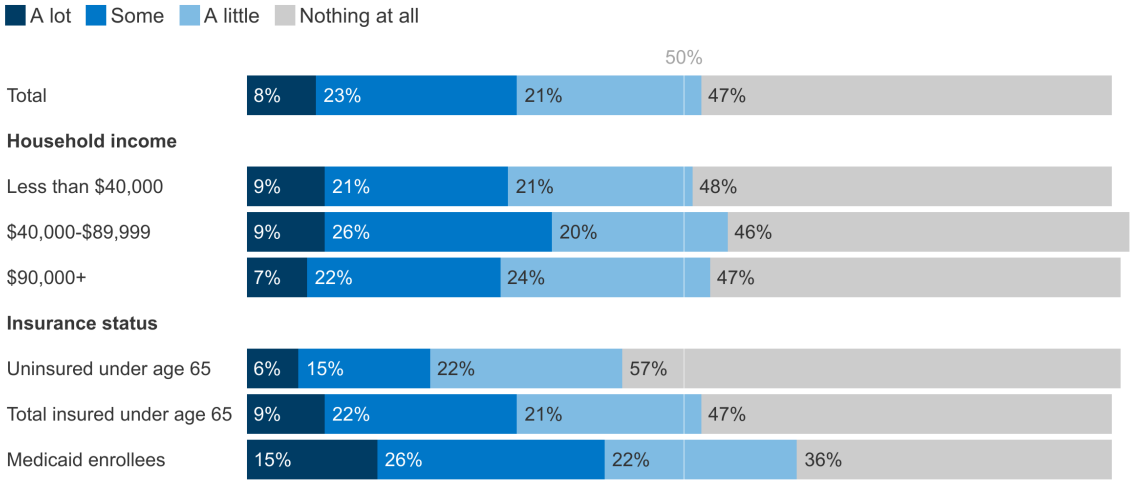
Medicaid Unwinding and the Inflation Reduction Act (IRA)

Enacted at the start of the pandemic, the Families First Coronavirus Response Act (FFCRA) required state Medicaid programs to keep people enrolled throughout the COVID-19 public health emergency (PHE). However, the Consolidated Appropriations Act (CAA) ended continuous enrollment on March 31, 2023, and required states to conduct redeterminations for all Medicaid enrollees by the end of May 2024. As of November 27, 2023, more than 11 million people have been disenrolled from Medicaid, and by KFF estimates, up to 24 million people could be disenrolled from Medicaid during this period of unwinding of the continuous enrollment provision. Just over half (53%) of U.S. adults say they have heard at least “a little” about states removing adults and children from Medicaid as the pandemic policies end, while half (47%) have heard nothing at all about this. Adults who are currently on Medicaid are most likely to say they have heard of this (65%).

Figure 10

Large Shares Of The Public Are Unaware Of Medicaid Unwinding; Those Currently On Medicaid Are Most Aware

How much have you heard, if anything, about states removing adults and children from Medicaid as pandemic policies end?



NOTE: See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Oct. 31-Nov. 7, 2023)

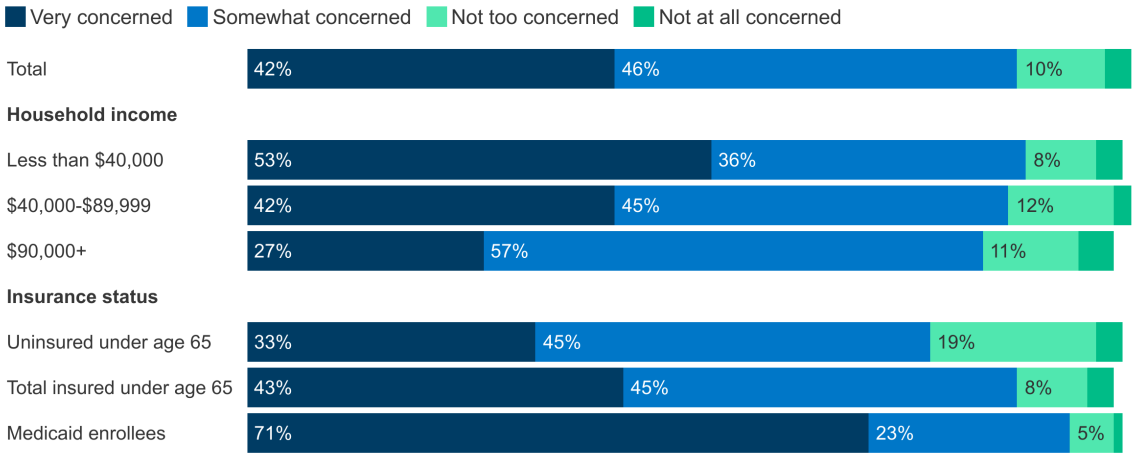
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Many states are working to support their Medicaid enrollees in the active renewal process, but enrollees may face barriers renewing Medicaid enrollment. Among those who have heard at least a little about the issue of Medicaid unwinding, a large majority are very (42%) or somewhat (46%) concerned about more adults and children becoming uninsured because of problems obtaining and renewing their coverage through Medicaid. Adults with household incomes under $40,000 and those currently on Medicaid are the most likely to say they are very concerned.

Figure 11

Of Those Who Are Aware Of Medicaid Unwinding, Large Majorities Are Concerned About People Becoming Uninsured

How concerned, if at all, are you about more adults and children becoming uninsured because of problems with obtaining and renewing their coverage through Medicaid?



NOTE: Asked of those who say they have heard at least "a little" about states removing adults and children from Medicaid as pandemic policies end. See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Oct. 31-Nov. 7, 2023)

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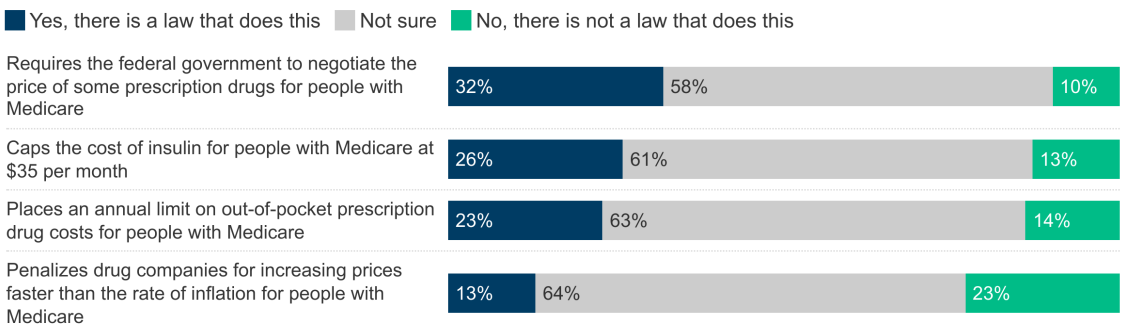
INFLATION REDUCTION ACT

More than a year after being signed into law, few adults are aware of the prescription drug regulations included in the Inflation Reduction Act (IRA). About one-fourth are aware that there are federal laws in place that cap monthly insulin costs at $35 for people with Medicare (26%) or that place a limit on annual out-of-pocket drug costs for people with Medicare (23%), and even fewer adults are aware there is a law in place that penalizes drug companies for increasing prices faster than the rate of inflation for people with Medicare (13%). These shares are relatively unchanged from when KFF first explored this in July 2023. However, slightly larger shares of adults now than in July say they are aware that there is a federal law in place that requires the federal government to negotiate the price of some prescription drugs for people with Medicare (32% v. 25% in July). This may be related to the media coverage of the recent announcement by HHS regarding the first 10 drugs covered under Medicare Part D selected for negotiation.

Figure 12

Majorities Of The Public Do Not Know About Inflation Reduction Act Provisions

As far as you know, is there a federal law in place that...



NOTE: See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Oct. 31-Nov. 7, 2023)

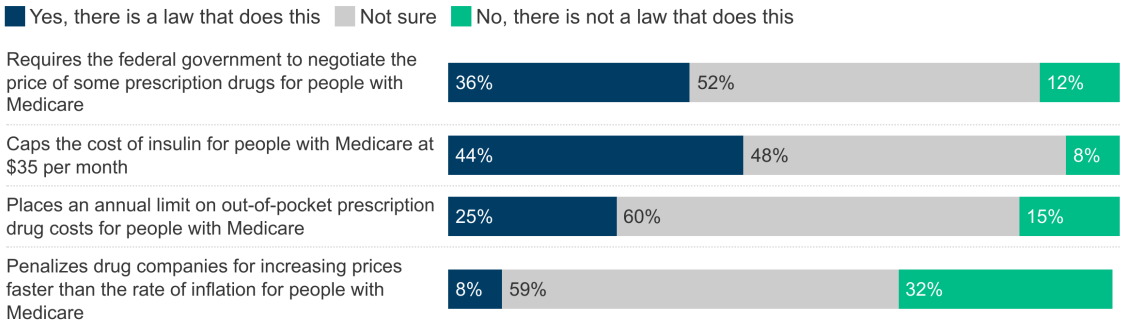
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While adults ages 65 and older are more likely to say they are aware of the Inflation Reduction Act's cap on the cost of insulin for people with Medicare (44%) than younger adults, majorities are still unaware of these provisions. Few seniors are aware that there is a federal law requiring the federal government to negotiate drug costs (36%), placing an annual limit on out-of-pocket drug costs (25%), or penalizing drug companies for increasing prices faster than the rate of inflation for people with Medicare (8%).

Figure 13

A Minority Of Adults Ages 65 And Over Know About The Medicare Prescription Drug Provisions In The Inflation Reduction Act

As far as you know, is there a federal law in place that...



NOTE: Among adults ages 65 and older. See topline for full question wording.
SOURCE: KFF Health Tracking Poll (Oct. 31-Nov. 7, 2023)

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